

are quite content living with our flaws. Besides, even if you're aware of your flaws, that still doesn't mean you are aware of how to fix those flaws. This is where we come in, and try and get you to learn new ways of analysing your problems and to think out of the box (or rather out of your own brain).

JUGAAD

Every Indian knows this word, and has indulged in some jugaad (जुगाड़) of their own. It's almost a national obsession, to just find a way to get things to work with the resources at hand. The word has no simple translation to English, though "winging it" might be a close fit. All cultures and countries have their own versions of jugaad, and for good reason too. Turns out, it might just be the natural order to be that way...

If you look at how natural selection works, it's small changes being made, which are then put to the survivability test, and if the changes are beneficial, the group survives, and if they are detrimental, the group perishes. Thus, good genes propagate and bad genes die out. Sometimes, the change has no real effect on the survivability of the group, and it just remains in some part of the population. If you replace genes with ideas, you get the basic workings of jugaad. We come up with small innovations that are more spur of the moment, rather than well-planned, and then those innovations are put to a test. Since most jugaad happens in colleges, let's take an example and break it down. We've all seen the famous cooler and pants jugaad, where a pant is attached to the cooler and one leg each blows air into two different rooms. Perhaps not the most efficient way of doing things, but it certainly would have felt a little cooler to students in the different rooms. They would have looked around the hostel and tried various things, presumably, before settling on this idea that seemed to work, and once it did work, they stopped trying to perfect it. Just good enough to work is the aim, and the idea survives. Just as with nature, where our bodies have obvious flaws in them that make it impossible to believe that this was an intelligent

design that was done from scratch, ideas like the cooler-pants solution are clearly not planned in advance. Natural selection works with what it has on hand already, without using anything external, as does jugaad.

In essence, jugaad is the way the world works naturally, and that's the reason why we Indians and other cultures as well, are so good at it. Jugaad also arises more in countries of larger populations and lower incomes, because it is more important in such places, as often, the survival of people is at stake. In China, they have the same way of thinking, and they have their own word for it. It's called 'chàbùduō' (差不多), which roughly translates to 'almost', or 'close enough' – as in, 'not perfect, but close enough'.



The cooler and pants jugaad

INTELLIGENT DESIGN

In order to get efficiency however, one has to use some form of planning and introduce something new to the equation. Buying materials to construct a new cooler to properly vent air in two different directions would have been an engineering solution. It would be carefully planned, and then implemented, and would fit the definition of 'intelligent design'.

Jugaad can get stuff done, but engineering a solution is the 'right way' to go about it. In professional settings across India and China, jugaad and chàbùduō are considered negatives, and if you are accused of using those methods in your professional life, it's usually an insult. Another way we talk about this attitude in India, in Hindi, is to have a 'chalta hai' (चलता है) attitude.

Globally too, when many Indians and Chinese (and other Asians as well) go abroad to work (in Europe and the Americas, especially), they find that this attitude can land them

in trouble. This is because there are strict codes that have been established and need to be followed by workers in these countries, which may be unheard of in the native countries. This is especially the case for hygiene standards in food service, or for building standards, safety standards, etc. This is one of the reasons why these attitudes have been treated as negatives, instead of looking at it in a positive light, as getting things done.

TINKERING

There's a big difference between chàbùduō / jugaad and being a tinkerer. A tinkerer is essentially a person who loves to pull things apart, see how they work, and then 'tinker' with them to improve them. To use the aforementioned cooler example above, a tinkerer would take apart the cooler and re-work it. Unlike an engineer who would purpose build something to cool the two rooms, a tinkerer would add on to it, and make a contraption to enhance the cooling, instead of just attaching a pair of pants or building something new from scratch. Generally, a tinkerer has knowledge or gains knowledge about how something works, and then improves on it.

The reason we're spending so much time writing about these differences, is because we want to precisely explain why we think it's important for all of us to be tinkerers, and how we can all achieve that level of competence. If you want to be better at work, or your life in general, you're going to have to tinker, and do it all the time. Tinkerers get things done, and they're achievers. Many entrepreneurs start off tinkering with things, and many of them are very successful because of this skill they have. And it's not a skill that people have to be born with, it's merely a mindset that you have to buy into.

Of course, most of us do not have the luxury of physically tinkering with things anymore. Tinkering has become more of a hobby, and we all usually have one unfinished project stored somewhere – this writer has several amps, speakers and various electronics he means to try and repair someday when he gets spare time. But that's not the tinkering that this story is about...

